"To call me in this kind of situation would not have been easy for anyone. If at that age, she could have that courage to call me, then I said I'll be up for it," says Rana. "There was nothing to lose. We had lost everything." He had only one precondition. "If we start digging up the past, a lot of things will come out, which will not be good for me, her or the country," Rana recalls telling her.

That meeting would prove to be a turning point in Manu's life. At the Paris Olympics this July-August, she not only won two bronzes to become India's first female shooter to medal but also the first athlete in independent India to win two medals at an Olympics, a milestone that will be tough to beat. This, then, is the inside story of how Manu buried the ghosts of her failure and self-doubt in Tokyo to reinvent herself as the pistol-packing champion at Paris who would do India immensely proud.

MOVING ON, SETTING TARGETS

That night, Sumedha Bhaker, Manu's mother, who was waiting eagerly for the update, felt a weight off her mind when she saw her daughter's reaction—a huge smile. Sumedha, a former school principal, had always stood behind her daughter. Even now, she is a constant presence at the Karni Singh shooting range in New Delhi, where Manu practises at both the 10m and 25m ranges. A spirited woman, she had herself fired off a series of messages to Rana in March 2021 after he left her daughter in tears at the ISSF World Cup in New Delhi by choosing to wear one of Sumedha's earlier messages on a T-shirt—"*Mil gayi khushi na*. Congratulations to you... *aapko apna ego mubaarak* [Are you happy now? Hope your



JASPAL RANA
Manu's coach for the Paris Games

"WITH HER HELP, I AM NO LONGER CARRYING ON MY HEAD THE BLAME THAT HAD BEEN HAUNTING ME FOR THE LAST TWO YEARS. IT IS THE BIGGEST RELIEF I HAVE FELT IN MY LIFE"

ego is satisfied now"]. Infuriated, Sumedha recalls, "I told him he didn't do right by her, that he had broken her heart, that he'd never find a student as good as her."

So with the coffee diplomacy at the Khan Market cafe, it wasn't just Manu who was starting afresh with Rana, Sumedha, too, was turning the page for the well-being of her daughter. On July 26, 2024, a day before the air pistol competition in Paris, she told Rana that she wanted the Manu-Rana "jodi" to be a "hit". "*Arjun aur Dronarcharya ke roop mein dekhna chahti hoon* [I want to see you like Arjun and Dronacharya]," she told INDIA TODAY, recalling the conversation. "*Shaayad jis guruji ne itni mehnat karwayee, woh guruji wahaan thhe hi nahin, bhagwan woh khushi dena hi nahin chaahte the* [Perhaps the teacher wasn't there in Tokyo, God did not

FLYING HIGH

It isn't all work and no play for the feisty miss. A few extra-curricular shots from the shooter's life



ANI



FRENCH CONNECTION
With coach Jaspal Rana and her two bronzes in front of the Eiffel Tower after the haul at the Paris Olympics in July-August